Inside Georgia's Push to Rebuild Trust in Elections

From: PBS NewsHour Mined: 2026-10-28 5 min read

In a small warehouse in Paulding County, Georgia, about an hour west of Atlanta, workers are unpacking voting machines and running tests for logic and accuracy. The checks are part of a statewide routine as Georgia prepares for **midterm elections** next month, designed to make sure every vote is counted correctly.

At the county election headquarters, equipment is organized and sent out to **polling places**. The **ballot scanners**, made by Dominion Voting Systems, are each secured and locked in six different places to prevent **tampering**. Lacy Dunn, the assistant elections director in Paulding County, says workers test every race, every candidate, every piece of equipment, and every ballot.

Overseeing the work statewide is Brad Raffensperger, Georgia's Republican secretary of state for the past eight years. He says his team stays in daily contact with all 159 counties, focusing on training, **oversight**, and steady communication.

Georgia has been at the center of a national debate about elections ever since President Donald Trump made false claims about the state's role in the 2020 election. Raffensperger became widely known for refusing to help Trump overturn the 2020 result in Georgia. In January of this year, FBI agents searched the Fulton County election headquarters and seized hundreds of boxes of 2020 election material. Almost nine months later, the FBI has yet to bring charges.

The debate has left some voters unsure. One voter said they believe there may have been a problem in 2020, while another said they feel optimistic that their vote will be counted this time. Now, in the last election he will oversee, Raffensperger is pushing back on efforts by the Trump administration to take more control over elections. Georgia, like 30 other states, refused to turn over sensitive voter information to the Department of Justice.

Word Treasure

ballot scanners -- Machines that read marked ballots and count the votes on them.

tampering -- Secretly changing or interfering with something so it no longer works fairly.

midterm elections -- Elections held in the middle of a president's term to choose other offices.

polling places -- Places where people go to cast their votes on election day.

oversight -- Watching over work carefully to check that it is done correctly.

Background you need

Elections are how voters choose the people who will hold public office.

Voting machines and ballot scanners record and count the votes that people cast.

Before voting begins, election workers test the equipment to check that every race, candidate, and ballot is handled correctly.

When voters trust that votes are counted correctly, they are more likely to trust the result of an election.

Break it down

LEAD: Georgia election workers are testing voting machines before next month's midterm elections to rebuild voter confidence.

KEY EVENT: Statewide checks of voting equipment, run from county headquarters and overseen by the secretary of state.

+- WHO: Workers in Paulding County, assistant elections director Lacy Dunn, and Secretary of State Brad Raffensperger.

+- WHAT: Unpacking voting machines, running logic and accuracy tests, and locking ballot scanners in six places.

+- WHERE: A warehouse and the election headquarters in Paulding County, Georgia, with work across all 159 counties.

EVIDENCE: Workers test every race, every candidate, every piece of equipment, and every ballot, according to Dunn.

OPEN QUESTION: Whether voters' confidence will be restored, and whether the FBI will bring charges over the seized 2020 material.

Why it matters

People need to believe their votes are counted correctly for election results to be accepted and for voters to keep taking part.

Test what you remember

1. Where are workers unpacking voting machines and running tests?

- (A) At the Department of Justice
- (B) In a stadium in Atlanta
- (C) In a small warehouse in Paulding County, Georgia
- (D) At the Fulton County election headquarters

2. In how many different places is each ballot scanner locked?

- (A) In ten places
- (B) In two places
- (C) In six places
- (D) In 159 places

3. Who oversees the election work statewide in Georgia?

- (A) Brad Raffensperger
- (B) Donald Trump
- (C) The FBI
- (D) Lacy Dunn

4. What did FBI agents do in January of this year, according to the article?

- (A) They tested ballot scanners
- (B) They searched the Fulton County election headquarters and seized hundreds of boxes of 2020 election material
- (C) They brought charges over the 2020 election
- (D) They counted votes in Paulding County

5. What did Georgia refuse to turn over to the Department of Justice?

- (A) Voting machines
- (B) Boxes of 2020 election material
- (C) Sensitive voter information
- (D) Ballot scanners

6. What does Lacy Dunn say workers test?

- (A) Only the ballots
- (B) Every race, every candidate, every piece of equipment, and every ballot
- (C) Only the candidates
- (D) Only the voting machines

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: C 3: A 4: B 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

1. A voter who is unsure: They believe there may have been a problem in 2020.
2. A voter who is optimistic: They feel their vote will be counted this time.
3. Brad Raffensperger: He is pushing back on efforts by the Trump administration to take more control over elections.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):